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The Rooms You're Paying For But Not Selling

How to See (and Fill) Every Empty Night Across Your Property

Most serviced apartment operators think their occupancy is higher than it actually is. They remember the sold-out weekends and forget the empty weeknights. This guide gives you the exact formula to calculate your real occupancy rate, shows you the three biggest causes of invisible vacancy, and walks you through a free fix you can start today.

What's inside:

- Why most operators overestimate their occupancy
- The occupancy and RevPAR formulas (with worked examples)
- The 3 biggest causes of invisible vacancy
- A free weekly occupancy tracker you can start using today
- What real-time occupancy visibility looks like at scale
- A self-assessment scorecard for your property

A free visibility guide by Algolog Limited | spacer.so

THE OCCUPANCY BLIND SPOT

Most serviced apartment operators think their occupancy is higher than it actually is. And it's not because they're bad at their job — it's because of how human memory works.

You remember the busy weekends. You remember the sold-out Friday night, the back-to-back Saturday bookings, the WhatsApp messages flying in with enquiries. What you don't remember — or don't track — is the empty Tuesday. The vacant Wednesday. The room that sat unbooked for four consecutive weeknights while you were focused on the weekend rush.

The reality is this: most 10-unit serviced apartment properties in Nigeria operate at 50–65% occupancy. That means 35–50% of their room-nights generate zero revenue.

Here's the part that makes this painful:

You're paying rent, electricity, DSTV, cleaning, and security on every room, every day — whether a guest is in it or not. An empty room doesn't cost nothing. It costs everything except the revenue it was supposed to generate.

What it's costing you:

[Total rooms] × [Empty nights per month] × [Your nightly rate] = Revenue left on the table

For a 10-unit property with 35% vacancy at NGN 30,000/night:
- 10 rooms × 30 days = 300 total room-nights
- 35% vacancy = 105 empty room-nights
- 105 × NGN 30,000 = NGN 3.15 million in potential revenue sitting on the table every month

This isn't a theoretical number. It's the gap between what your property could earn and what it actually earns. And the first step to closing that gap is knowing the gap exists.

KNOW YOUR REAL NUMBER — THE OCCUPANCY FORMULA

Before you can fix your occupancy, you need to know your occupancy. Not a guess. Not a feeling. An actual number. Here are the two formulas every property operator should know.

Formula 1: Occupancy Rate

(Total Booked Room-Nights ÷ Total Available Room-Nights) × 100 = Occupancy Rate

Worked example — 10-unit property, 30-day month:

- Total available room-nights: 10 × 30 = 300
- If 195 were booked: 195 ÷ 300 = 65% occupancy
- That means 105 room-nights earned nothing

Formula 2: RevPAR (Revenue Per Available Room)

Total Room Revenue ÷ Total Available Room-Nights = RevPAR

Using the same example:

- You earned NGN 5.85M from 195 booked nights
- RevPAR = NGN 5,850,000 ÷ 300 = NGN 19,500
- Your nightly rate is NGN 30,000 — but you're only making NGN 19,500 per room per night when you account for the empty ones

> "RevPAR is the number that tells you the truth. Your nightly rate is what you charge. RevPAR is what you actually earn."

Most operators focus on their nightly rate and ignore RevPAR. But RevPAR is the number that determines whether your property is profitable or just busy on weekends.

THE 3 BIGGEST CAUSES OF INVISIBLE VACANCY

If your occupancy is below 75%, it's not random bad luck. There are usually three structural causes — and most operators are dealing with at least two of them.

Cause 1: No Midweek Strategy

Weekends tend to fill themselves — especially in cities like Abuja and Kaduna where short-stay demand spikes Friday through Sunday. But Tuesday, Wednesday, and Thursday? Those nights consistently underperform.

Most operators don't even track which days of the week are weakest. They accept that "midweek is always slow" without doing anything targeted about it. But "slow" and "empty" are different problems. Slow means low demand. Empty means no strategy to capture the demand that does exist.

Cause 2: No Gap-Fill Pricing

A room sitting empty tonight at NGN 30,000 will earn NGN 0 tomorrow. A room sold tonight at NGN 20,000 earns NGN 20,000. The maths is straightforward.

But many operators would rather leave a room empty than "discount" it. There's a psychological resistance to lowering prices — it feels like devaluing the property. Here's the reality: an empty room costs money (rent, electricity, cleaning, security). A discounted room makes money. The real devaluation is leaving revenue on the table.

Cause 3: No Visibility Into Patterns

Without data, you can't see that Room 7 has been empty every Monday through Wednesday for the last 3 months. You can't see that your occupancy drops 40% the week after salary week. You can't see that your best-performing unit is carried by repeat guests while your worst-performing unit hasn't had a booking in 12 days.

You can't act on patterns you can't see. And without a tracking system — even a simple one — these patterns remain invisible.

THE FREE FIX — DO THIS TODAY

You don't need software to start understanding your occupancy. Here's a simple, manual tracking system you can set up today in a notebook, Google Sheet, or Excel spreadsheet.

Your free step-by-step fix:

1. **Create a simple weekly tracker.**
   Columns: Week | Room 1 | Room 2 | ... | Room 10 | Total Booked | Total Available | Occupancy %. Mark each cell as booked or empty for each night of the week.

2. **Fill it in every Friday afternoon.**
   It takes 10 minutes. Look at your bookings for the week, mark which rooms were occupied each night, and calculate the totals.

3. **After 4 weeks, calculate your real monthly occupancy.**
   Not a guess, not a feeling — an actual number. Add up all booked nights, divide by total available nights, multiply by 100.

4. **After 8 weeks, look for patterns.**
   Which rooms consistently underperform? Which days of the week are weakest? Which weeks of the month dip? The patterns will be obvious once you have the data.

Sample weekly occupancy tracker:

Week of:	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun	Booked	Avail	Occ %
Room 1	—	—	—	▯	▯	▯	▯	**4**	7	**57%**
Room 2	▯	▯	—	—	▯	▯	▯	**5**	7	**71%**
Room 3	—	—	—	—	▯	▯	—	**2**	7	**29%**
TOTAL								**11**	21	**52%**

Once you have 4–8 weeks of data, act on what you see:

- Midweek occupancy below 40%? ▯ Create a midweek promo (e.g., 3-night stay, pay for 2)
- Same rooms always empty? ▯ Check pricing, check listing quality, consider different marketing for those units
- Post-salary-week dip? ▯ Pre-book loyal customers with a standing reservation offer

An honest note:

Tracking by hand gives you the data. But it's backward-looking — you see what happened, not what's happening now. And it can't alert you to opportunities in real time. By the time you notice Room 3 has been empty all week, the week is already over.

A manual tracker tells you where the problem was. Automation tells you where the opportunity is — right now.

THE AUTOMATED FIX — WHAT REAL-TIME VISIBILITY LOOKS LIKE

Here's what changes when occupancy tracking happens automatically, in real time, across every room in your property:

The automated workflow:

1. **Live occupancy dashboard.**
   Updated in real time, not at the end of the week. You open the dashboard and see exactly which rooms are occupied, which are empty, and which have upcoming bookings. Right now, not last Friday.

2. **Automatic gap detection.**
   The system flags rooms that have been empty for 3 or more consecutive days. Instead of discovering this on Friday afternoon, you know on Tuesday morning — while you can still do something about it.

3. **Occupancy trends by day, week, and season.**
   See that your Tuesdays consistently run at 35% occupancy. See that the second week of every month dips. See that December outperforms every other month by 40%. Patterns become visible and actionable.

4. **RevPAR tracking.**
   Know your actual earning power per room, not just your listed nightly rate. This single number tells you more about your property's health than any other metric.

5. **Dynamic pricing suggestions.**
   "Room 4 is empty Tuesday through Thursday. Similar rooms in your area are selling at NGN 22,000. Consider a midweek rate." Actionable pricing intelligence, not just data.

6. **Automated promotion triggers.**
   When occupancy drops below a threshold you set, the system can send targeted offers to past guests. "Stay midweek this month and get 30% off." No manual effort required.

7. **Booking trend forecasting.**
   See next week's expected occupancy before it happens, based on current bookings and historical patterns. Act proactively instead of reactively.

This is what Spacer gives property operators — not just a booking tool, but a revenue visibility engine.

Currently managing 500+ bookings monthly across properties in Abuja and Kaduna. Live dashboards. Occupancy analytics. Gap detection. Dynamic pricing tools. Everything you need to see and fill every empty night across your property.

YOUR OCCUPANCY HEALTH CHECK

Answer these five statements honestly. Count how many are true for your property.

#	Statement	Yes / No
1	I don't know my exact occupancy rate for last month	
2	I can't tell you which day of the week has the lowest bookings	
3	I've had rooms sit empty for 5+ consecutive days without taking action	
4	I don't have a different strategy for midweek vs weekends	
5	I've never calculated my RevPAR	

Your score:

0–1: Your visibility is better than most. You likely have systems in place — or a very small property where you can track things manually. Smart automation would still save you time and reveal patterns you can't see by hand.

2–3: You have blind spots that are costing you real money. You're making decisions based on intuition rather than data, and some of those decisions are leaving revenue on the table. Start with the free tracker on Page 5 — it will change how you think about your property within a month.

4–5: You're operating in the dark. Rooms are sitting empty, revenue is being left on the table, and you don't have the visibility to know where or why. This is the single biggest thing you can fix to increase your property's revenue — and it starts with knowing your numbers.

FREE 15-MINUTE PROPERTY TECH AUDIT

We only do 10 of these per month so we can give each property our full attention.

In 15 minutes, we'll review your current occupancy tracking, identify where revenue is being left on the table, and show you what real-time visibility looks like for your specific property.

No obligation. No pressure. Just a useful conversation.

Book your free audit:

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This guide was prepared by Algolog Limited, a Nigerian technology company that builds management systems for hospitality and workspace businesses. Our platform, Spacer (spacer.so), manages 500+ bookings monthly across properties in Abuja and Kaduna.

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